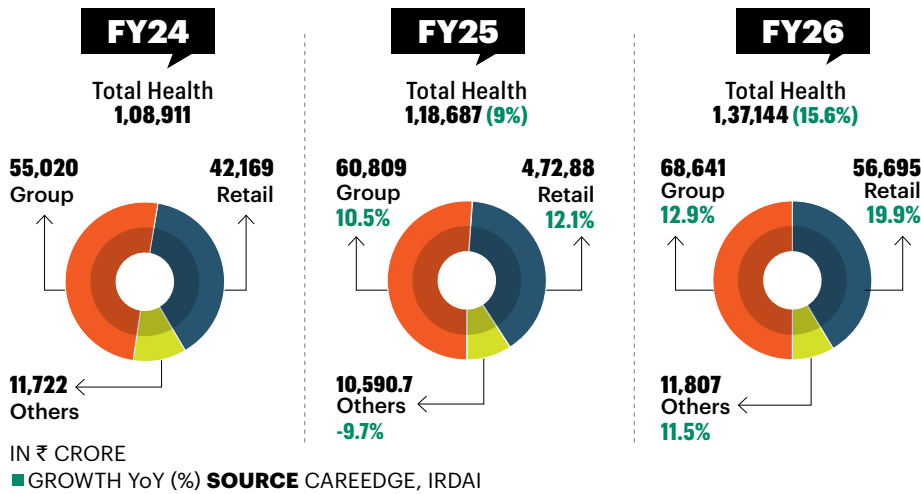
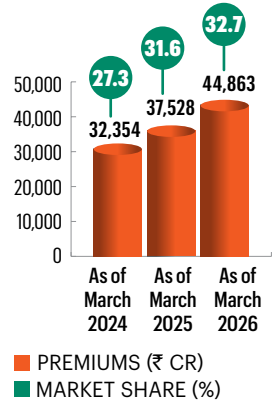


COSTLIER COVER

● Retail health premiums rose a steep 19.9% in FY26



STANDALONE HEALTH INSURERS GAIN MARKET SHARE



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insurance. This segment is characterised by informal employment, unstable incomes, and the absence of social security benefits, leaving them vulnerable. Expanding employer-linked models to gig workers and micro, small and medium enterprises, along with modular, affordable products for families, will accelerate coverage, he says. Joshi of SBI General Insurance calls for a multi-pronged effort to widen the market, including simplifying products, and strengthening advisory-led distribution.

“At the same time, increasing focus on improving health insurance accessibility across Tier 2, Tier 3 and Tier 4 markets in the deeper Bharat is essential as these regions represent the next phase of insurance growth and financial inclusion,” he adds. Experts say as India’s per capita income grows and insurers continue to innovate offerings, the penetration of health insurance policies will increase.

Cashless treatments and ease of claim settlement have also been friction points over the years. Joshi



SIDDHARTH SINGHAL
HEAD, HEALTH
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“Premiums have to mimic hospitalisation costs because, at the end of the day, insurance companies are money managers. If the claim outgo is on the higher side, the premiums have to reflect that”

of Probus says insurance companies are using AI (artificial intelligence) tools to automate documentation and speed up discharge.

“Generally, it takes time for the claim to settle because they do their investigations. AI tools are being used so that the case work is speeded up, and the client gets fast discharge,” she says. The Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India’s (IRDAI’s) introduction of a 60-minute turnaround time for cashless claim authorisations has noticeably improved the customer claims experience, says Joshi of SBI General Insurance.

The IRDAI has also over the years taken steps to ease the bottlenecks and widen the health insurance coverage. With health care costs only expected to go up, buying an insurance policy and not waiting for an emergency health issue may be your best bet. Experts say insurance will deliver the greatest value if you buy at a younger age and well before health risks emerge. **BT**

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